

## Interview NAWAZ SHARIF

# "The verdict is Mr Musharraf we have had enough"

*The good showing by PML(N), headed by Nawaz Sharif, which emerged as the second largest party in the elections has catapulted the former prime minister into the role of a kingmaker in the new dispensation. As his party celebrated by dancing to the beat of the dhol, Sharif spoke exclusively to Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA at his Model Town residence in Lahore about what he sees as the future of Pakistan. Excerpts:*

**Q. What is the big message that the people of Pakistan are conveying from the results of this election?**

**A.** The people have said that Mr Musharraf we have had enough of you. We want democracy and not dictatorship. That message is loud and clear. Mr Musharraf had said that if the people decide that he is not required, he will step down. Well, the people have now decided.

**Q. Were you surprised by your party's success in the elections given that you had said that the polling would be rigged?**

**A.** There was no level playing field in these elections. The Government

**Q. Why do you think so?**

**A.** If we don't do this then we have nothing. We cannot stop the army's intervention in Pakistan in the future. Once we restore the judiciary it would become independent and would check the army's interference in politics. It would know that in future nobody can dismiss it.

**Q. Does this match the PPP's agenda? After all it has been speaking of the independence of the judiciary rather than restoration?**

this man has to serve as President of the country he must take a judgement from that judiciary whom he sacked on the issue of eligibility.

**Q. What role do you expect the army to now play?**

**A.** To abide by the Constitution. We have no expectations from the army other than the professional work that they are doing. They shouldn't meddle in politics. The signals that the present chief of army staff has sent are quite positive.



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## "Reinstatement of the sacked judiciary will be the lifeline of Pakistan's democracy. Otherwise we cannot stop the army's intervention in future."

rigged it sufficiently, otherwise no way could the King's party have secured the number of seats it got. We have come back by defying the rules of the game set by Mr Musharraf and we have defeated him. I see the outcome as the beginning of a major transition.

**Q. What should be the agenda of the new coalition government?**

**A.** First and foremost is the reinstatement of the judiciary that was sacked. Doing that is most important. I would say it is the lifeline of Pakistan's democracy.

**What if the PPP doesn't agree to it?**

**A.** If our agendas don't meet then we continue our struggle until we get what the nation wants. It would be difficult to join with them without really getting the judiciary restored. This is the main difference of opinion between the two.

**Q. Would you push for President Musharraf's impeachment?**

**A.** I don't want to talk about impeachment. I think this matter needs to be handled in a different manner. The judiciary must be restored and if

**Q. Benazir talked of religious fundamentalists being the biggest threat to Pakistan. How would you deal with the question of terrorism?**

**A.** Fundamentalism, extremism, radicalism these are the so-called gifts of dictatorship. They thrive under dictatorship. Democracy is the best answer. We never had any problem like that when we were in the government. I condemn terrorism whether in Pakistan or anywhere in the world. But we have got to handle it sensibly. The new Parliament can sit down and devise a strategy where we can really resolve this problem. Think we need to win the hearts and minds of the people. You can't settle all matters with guns and bullets.

**Q. Will relations with India change under the new government?**

**A.** It will be a change for good.